from transhumance and/or nomadic pastoralism into a *more* sedentist and courtly imperial lineage, commanding (at least for a few decades) an ostensibly Perso-Islamic empire *via* a seasonally transhumant elite. The logically following lines of investigation, then, would encompass at least an approximate timeframe in which this transformation occurred, and the possible impetuses behind it. Moreover, how thorough was the transformation – were pre-imperial mores relinquished completely, or maintained to a discernible degree even as the Shansabanis attained regional and then transregional prominence? Finally, what role did Islam play in the process? Again, the architectural remains within historical Ghur provide a unique point of departure for answering these questions.

Processes of socio-political transformation are virtually impossible to recuperate from textual sources alone: as we have seen, the Shansabanis' pre-imperial history is not thoroughly reported even by Juzjani (cf. Chapter 1), surely in part due to their less than favorable "barbarian" origins. At the same time, material culture primarily records these subtle and *longue durée* processes' outcomes, such as manifest alterations in the built environment, rather than the processes themselves (cf. Introduction and Chapter 1). However, consideration of the available traces in conjunction with each other, and with anthropological studies documenting shifts in lifeways and economies within modern transhumant and/or nomadic societies, may provide informative parallels for conceiving of the Shansabanis' historical transformation.

It was argued earlier in this chapter that the pre-imperial Shansabanis and other Ghuris of the eleventh and early twelfth centuries, still practitioners of varying degrees of transhumance/nomadism, repurposed or reused Ghur's extensive architectural remains. In the present attempt to recreate with some plausibility their process of transition toward regional politico-economic dominance, the recent rediscovery of a *minar*-like tower at the rural settlement of Da Qadi (Figure 2.17), 75 km southwest of Jam-Firuzkuh, may prove to be extremely fortuitous. The *minar* gives credence to Juzjani's mention of such a structure at the site of Qala'-yi Zarmurgh, which has been plausibly located in the vicinity of Da Qadi. Moreover, Zarmurgh was supposedly the place of origin of the above-described rube-become-cosmopolitan Amir Banji, the legendary progenitor of the Shansabanis during the eighth–ninth centuries.[65] This significant rediscovery may signal and even help to date the early phases of the Shansabanis' public avowal of Islam – rather than their conversion per se, as discussed below. Ultimately, it could help mark the beginning of the Shansabanis' ability to patronize skilled laborers with exposure to building practices that were *trans*regional, prevalent beyond Ghur's nomad–urban continuum, and which were increasingly pertinent as the Shansabanis began to emulate their imperial contemporaries the Saljuqs and the Ghaznavids.